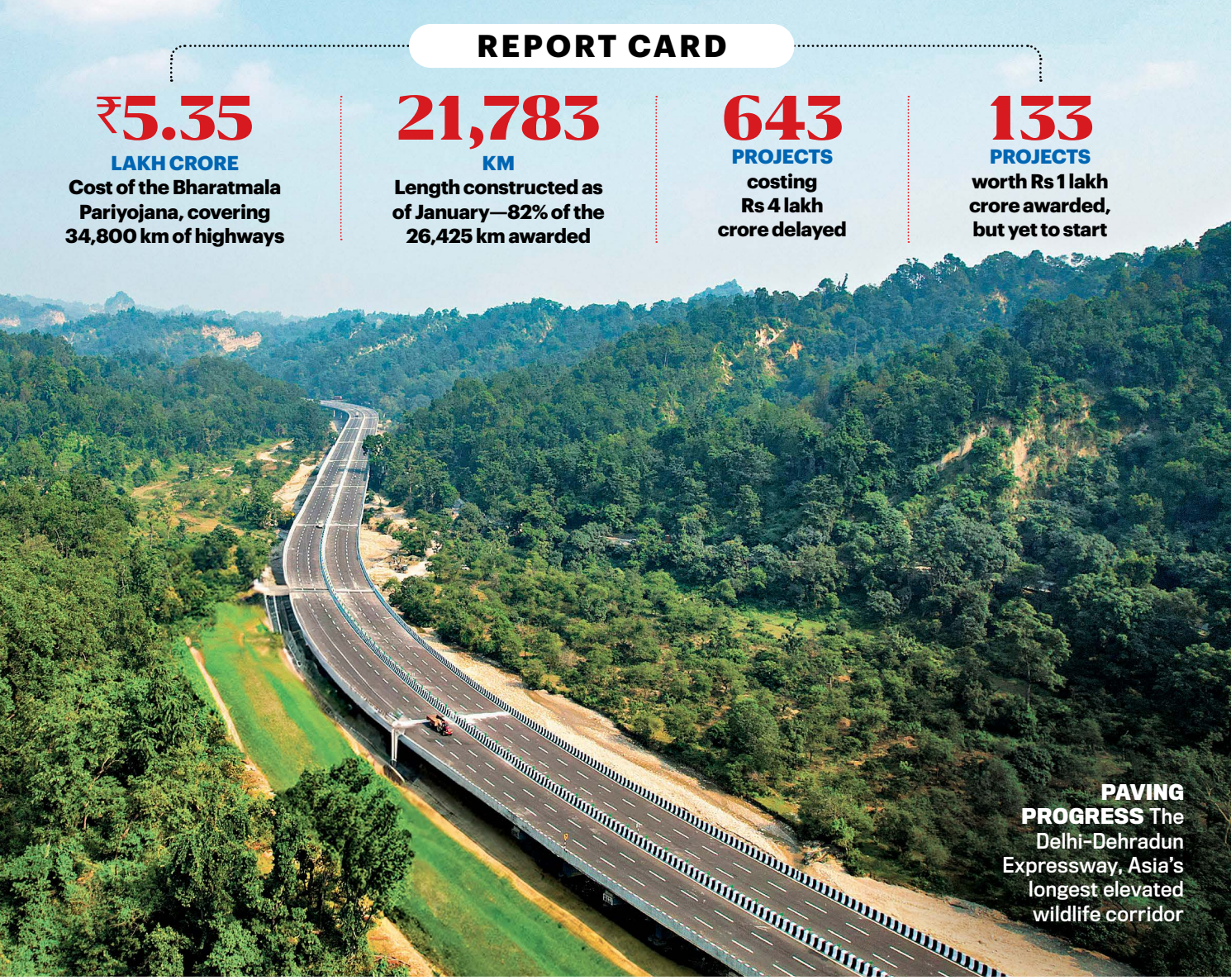
REPORT CARD

₹5.35
LAKH CROORE
Cost of the Bharatmala Pariyojana, covering 34,800 km of highways

21,783
KM
Length constructed as of January—82% of the 26,425 km awarded

643
PROJECTS
costing Rs 4 lakh crore delayed

133
PROJECTS
worth Rs 1 lakh crore awarded, but yet to start



PAVING PROGRESS The Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, Asia's longest elevated wildlife corridor

increased household incomes and expenditure, and improved access to markets, schools and healthcare.

The shift in economics is already evident on the ground. Ahmedabad-based exporters can now reach Dholera in one hour, down from two. Freight logistics companies are redesigning their routes around the Amritsar-Jamnagar corridor, expecting to spend less on fuel as well as make quicker turnarounds. Union minister of road transport and highways Nitin Gadkari says, "The Delhi-Mumbai Expressway will not just connect the two cities faster, but also link industrial hubs, strengthen Gati Shakti logistics, and accelerate growth across Gujarat, Rajasthan and Maharashtra." Similarly, the Bengaluru-Chennai Expressway, which can be covered in four hours, end-to-end, is expected to transform commuting, manufacturing supply chains and weekend travel between two of India's largest metros. "If you can reduce the commute between a big city and a nearby town to under two hours, you effectively redraw the city limits," says transport planning consultant Rajiv Saxena. "The town becomes an extension of the metropolis, offering a vital solution to urban housing and infrastructure pressures."

That optimism is also showing up in traffic and revenue forecasts. According to credit rating agency ICRA, vehicular traffic growth is expected to rise to 4-5 per cent in FY26 from about 2.5 per cent in FY25, driven by higher economic activity and a low base effect. "Given this," ICRA says, "the toll collection is expected to increase by 5-9 per cent in FY26 compared to around 6 per cent in FY25." J.P. Singh of the All India Transport Workers' Association (AITWA) says every hour saved in freight is money earned. "Faster trips, lower diesel, more runs a month. That's a pay rise."

COSTLY DELAYS

The broader picture, however, is not as rosy. The government says that 643 projects, worth roughly Rs 4 lakh crore, are still running behind schedule. More than 260 have been delayed by up to three years, and nearly 80 by over three years. Another 133, worth about Rs 1 lakh crore, have been awarded but not yet started. Among states, West Bengal, Punjab, Kerala and Jammu and Kashmir have around 40 per cent of Bharatmala roads complete, as against about 65 per cent in Gujarat and Maharashtra, home ground for the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, among other projects.